CHAPTER 53

JUST DON’T CALL IT BAZBALL

May 2022

The phone rings. It’s Brendon McCullum. I’ve been waiting for this call. By any stretch of the imagination, he is a left-field choice as the new long form coach of England as he has no coaching experience at this level. It is 14 years since I first bowled at him, the summer where indescribable magic flowed through my body and showed me that I might be capable of something more than I thought possible. We are different people now, Brendon with a career of innovative and inspiring aggressive cricket behind him.

He is quick with his words and gets to the point: ‘I just want to pick the strongest England team, and you will be in that.’ A smile moves across my face, another opportunity of rebirth. ‘You are very much in our plans.’ I am immediately excited, an energy filling me once again. I suddenly feel set apart from the grizzling, stubborn man I have found myself becoming on the field over the last few years. I have been walking the cricket field like a lone ranger who is paranoid someone is following them, clinging to my bowling spot as if it is constantly trying to be snatched away from me.

The first training sessions under Brendon and Ben are unlike any I’ve ever been part of for a cricket team. Brendon, referred to as Baz, speaks with immediate clarity about how he wants to play. I am struck by how eloquent he is and how clearly he is speaking from the heart. He is calm, clear and to the point. It’s a huge change from Chris Silverwood, who would address the team with pre-prepared notes. It’s incredible how quickly a message will land if a coach is looking a player in the eyes rather than at their notes. We are all immediately engaged. He says that he won’t be